

September 9, 2026

Professor Jane Economics
Recipient Title
Department of Economics
University of Iwanttoworkthere
Address Anywhere, OH 43210

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for the position of (Assistant Professor/) Post-doctoral Fellow of Economics at _____. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at The Ohio State University, specializing in behavioral theory and experimental economics. My research studies how individuals acquire information, allocate attention, and determine what to consider when making decisions. Across my work, I combine economic theory with controlled experiments to identify the mechanisms underlying behavior that may otherwise appear observationally similar.

My job market research examines costly information acquisition and rational inattention. A central challenge in this literature is that models with very different assumptions about information costs can often rationalize the same observed choices. My research develops an experimental approach that moves beyond final actions and directly studies how individuals choose information. In my main project, Costly Information and Beliefs: An Experiment, with Hyeonggyun Ko and Jason Paulo Tayawa, we compare environments in which subjects choose information through different but theoretically equivalent representations. The experiment allows us to distinguish behavioral implications of alternative models of information costs that are difficult to identify from choice data alone. More broadly, this work demonstrates that the representation through which individuals acquire information can reveal economically meaningful features of the information-acquisition process.

This project reflects a broader feature of my research agenda: I am interested not only in what people ultimately choose, but also in the intermediate decisions that determine what enters the choice process. My ongoing work develops this idea in several directions. One line of research studies how individuals determine the set of alternatives they are willing to consider when their future preferences or behavior are uncertain. In this work, I examine the tradeoff between flexibility and commitment and investigate whether stochastic choice reflects uncertainty about future tastes, temptation, or limits on consideration. Another strand of my research studies how alternative representations of the same information problem affect information acquisition, providing evidence on when theoretically equivalent formulations generate behaviorally different decisions. Together, these projects form a research program on attention, information, and consideration in decision-making.

[(Research Objective 1 – Focus: Experimental)] An important objective of my research is to design experiments that speak directly to economic theory. Rather than treating behavioral deviations as residual anomalies, I use experimental variation to distinguish competing mechanisms and to identify economically interpretable primitives. This approach creates natural connections between behavioral and experimental economics, decision theory, information economics, and applied microeconomics. Going forward, I plan to build on these connections by studying how endogenous attention and consideration interact with learning, uncertainty, and self-control. I am particularly interested in environments in which individuals must decide not only which option to choose, but also what information or alternatives should enter the decision process in the first place.

(Research Objective 2 – Focus: Applied/Environmental) An important objective of my research is to]

[(Institution-specific) I would be excited to develop this research agenda at _____. The department's strengths in behavioral economics, experimental economics, microeconomic theory, and/or information economics would provide an especially productive environment for my work. I would particularly welcome opportunities to interact with faculty working on _____. My research would complement these strengths by bringing an experimental approach to questions about information acquisition and consideration.]

I also hope to contribute to the broader intellectual community of the department. My experimental research has benefited enormously from collaboration across fields, and I would like to help create opportunities for faculty and students to develop and test ideas using experimental methods. This could include mentoring underrepresented students interested in experimental research, organizing workshops or informal research discussions, collaborating with theorists and applied researchers on experimental tests of economic mechanisms, and contributing to the development of shared experimental infrastructure where appropriate. Over time, I hope to help strengthen _____ as a place where theory and empirical behavioral research actively inform one another.

Teaching and mentorship are also central to the academic community I hope to build. At Ohio State University, I have taught undergraduate economics in both in-person and online settings and have worked with students with a wide range of backgrounds and preparation. My goal as an instructor is to help students see economic models not simply as formal objects, but as tools for understanding decisions they encounter in the world. I would be prepared to teach courses in behavioral economics, experimental economics, microeconomics, and related areas, while also contributing to the departments core undergraduate curriculum.

I am excited about the possibility of joining _____ and contributing to its research, teaching, and intellectual community. I am enclosing my Job Market Paper (If necessary)[and other research papers], my curriculum vitae, and (If necessary)[teaching evaluations/transcript]. Letters of recommendation from my advisor, Prof. John Rehbeck, and committee members Prof. Paul J. Healy and Prof. Aldo Lucia will be forwarded under separate cover by the Departmental Placement Coordinator. I am available for interviews. I can be reached by email at kim.8316@osu.edu, and by phone at (+1) 614-967-1573. Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my research and future plans with you.

Sincerely,

Suha Kim

Ph.D. Candidate

Department of Economics

Ohio State University